



**LINKED-IN:** Weise (second from left) and Blagsvedt registering villagers

## Maid for Each Other

**A social networking site provides job opportunities for the informal sector workers in Bangalore**

■ **By Nandini Vaish**

**W**ho said social networking sites were only for yuppies who wanted to make friends? These days they also help people search for store clerks, maids, cooks and drivers online. In Bangalore, Babajob.com is one such instance. This site charges Rs 500, which is split into a fee of Rs 300, once the hiring is complete, and Rs 200 goes to the one who registers the job seeker—cyber-café owner, intermediary or NGO. Launched in August 2007, it has 6,800 registered users, of which 3,000 are job-seekers and 1,500 employers. The rest are just “curious” onlookers. Besides its centre in the silicon city, the site has also been enabled in Hyderabad, Mumbai, Goa, Pune, Chennai, Delhi, Kolkata, and Coimbatore.

Bangalore resident Alok Sehgal found his driver, Akhilan, through Babajob.com. He read about it in a newspaper and gave it a try as the other drivers, who had come through word-of-mouth, “were not up to the mark”. About 20 drivers were looking for jobs near Indiranagar, where Sehgal stays. After contacting about seven of them, one replied. The best part, says Sehgal, is that there are photos, phone numbers and copies of their licences attached to their profiles. Though, it would have been better, he feels, if police verifications of



the prospective employees were also available. Similarly, 30-year-old Catherine, who now babysits for an American family says, “my friend told me about this site. After meeting the family, I was called for an interview.” She has been working with them for five months.

Babajob.com was founded by Americans Sean Blagsvedt, an ex-Microsoft employee, and his stepfather, Ira Weise, both of who live in the city. While researching, Blagsvedt came across the work of a Duke University economist, Anirudh Krishna, who said a majority of Indians live in poverty as they are unable to find jobs. That’s when it occurred to them: “We need a Linked-In for the villages!” Weise, who is the managing director of the site says, “we chose to launch this site, hoping the large number of informal sector workers will benefit from our efforts.”

The site has devised ways of reaching the unskilled workers who don’t have access to the Internet. For one, it advertises and sends its people into slums. NGOs and charities like Stree Jagriti Samiti also help by passing information. Word-of-mouth is another way people spread the news to their servants, who post their profiles on the site. They are also planning a tie-up with the Society for the Promotion of Area Resource Centres to mobilise people in Mumbai—their next stop.